

## 1.3

# Recognising the Structure of a Passage

### Topic Sentences: Part I

A topic sentence is also known as a focus sentence. A topic sentence is the main idea of a paragraph and is without any examples. A paragraph usually begins with a topic sentence. A topic sentence tells you what a paragraph is all about.

Every topic sentence has a topic and a controlling idea. The controlling idea gives a writer the focus of his/her writing.

#### Examples:

**Topic sentence** → Sabah has a lot of beautiful islands.

The topic is 'Sabah' and the controlling idea is 'has a lot of beautiful islands'.

**Topic sentence** → Amin is a hard-working employee.

The topic is 'Amin' and the controlling idea is 'a hard-working employee'.

### Exercise

1

Circle the topics and underline the controlling ideas.

- 1 New York is a busy city.
- 2 Being away from family teaches one to be independent.
- 3 A long semester break allows students to do a lot of things.
- 4 Cooking is a good activity that can strengthen family relationships.
- 5 Studying in groups has a lot of advantages.
- 6 Living alone has some disadvantages.
- 7 Staying with parents after marriage is practical.
- 8 Alternative medicine works better than modern drugs.
- 9 Modern inventions spoil people.
- 10 Teaching is a noble profession.

## Exercise

2

Write a topic sentence for each of the following topics. See the example given.

- (0) Poverty : Poor students need to be helped, so that they are able to survive in today's competitive world.
- 1 Education : Students should be educated so they are able to survive in the future world
- 2 Environment : We should protect our mother earth to ensure a clean and safe environment for the future generation
- 3 Customs : Customs play a important role in everyday life by providing structured ways to celebrate traditions.
- 4 Technology : The Internet has transformed our everyday life easier so that they can save their time to do faster their work.
- 5 Entertainment : Human nowadays like to play games to keep them entertained

## Topic Sentences: Part II

A topic sentence is usually found at the beginning of a paragraph. However, it is also found either in the middle or at the end of a paragraph. A topic sentence summarises the whole paragraph and it is written in a complete sentence.

### Example ①

**Mimi was very upset today.** She lost her new wallet which was given by her mother on her birthday last month. For her, the wallet was so special because it was a designer good and she had never received such a present before.

The first sentence is the topic sentence. The sentence does not have any elaboration or examples. It just states the main idea of the paragraph. The following sentences provide further elaboration on the topic sentence and are known as supporting details.

### Example ②

During the semester break, I visited my 55-year-old aunt. She was so happy that she could not express herself with words when my family and I spent a night at her house. Moreover, my cousins and I played some traditional games together. **I had a wonderful semester break this year.** I really enjoyed myself staying at the village playing traditional games that are almost forgotten by youngsters nowadays.

The topic sentence is embedded in the middle of the paragraph.



**Example 3**

Singapore has an excellent healthcare system. Medical services are provided to Singaporeans with reasonable prices. In addition, Singapore also has a high standard of education. Singapore qualifications are recognised worldwide. Many foreign students choose to continue their tertiary education in Singapore. In addition, Singapore is also a clean city. Citizens and tourists are punished if they litter the city. **To sum up, Singapore is one of the best countries in the world.**

The last sentence is the topic sentence. It summarises the whole paragraph.

**Exercise****1**

**Identify the topic sentence for each of the following paragraphs.**

- 1 **Travelling is an interesting activity to do.** When you travel, you have the opportunity to know other countries, cultures, customs, food and seasons. You will get a lot of knowledge and, at the same time, you can form new friendships with people that you meet on your journey.

**Topic sentence:** \_\_\_\_\_

- 2 Mrs Ainun is a Physics teacher. She is good at teaching Physics. She always assists her students in their learning. Sometimes, she stays back in school with students for extra classes. Besides, she is also a good motivator. She is ever willing to help weak students to do well in their studies. Her students really appreciate her. **To conclude, Mrs Ainun is a dedicated teacher.**

**Topic sentence:** \_\_\_\_\_

- 3 South Korea is famous for Samsung. There are many electrical gadgets under the brand, such as smartphones, refrigerators, air-conditioners and washing machines. **One cannot deny the fact that South Korea is an important country.** In addition, South Korea also manufactures Hyundai cars which are famous worldwide. The capital city is Seoul and nowadays, a lot of people like to visit South Korea due to the effects of the Korean Wave.

**Topic sentence:** \_\_\_\_\_

## Supporting Details

Supporting details refer to the facts, examples and explanations given to further develop the topic sentence.

**Example:**Topic  
sentence

I do not want my children to live in a big city. This is due to the fact that life in a city is hectic. There are a lot of traffic jams and everybody seems stressed out. A city environment is also not safe for the children since there are many crimes that happen in the city as compared to the countryside. Furthermore, the air in the city is polluted. There are many factories that release harmful gases in the atmosphere.

Supporting  
details**Exercise****1**

Write three supporting details for each of the following topic sentences.

- 1 My mother is the greatest mother on earth.

~~It is because my mum will prepare a great meal for me when i came back home. As an example , her specialty dish ,Rendang Chicken will always served on the table since i like it a lot.~~

~~-listen to my thought and help me solve together when i have problem~~

- 2 Lea is a good friend of mine.

~~-same interest like game and playing basketball~~

~~-understand my feeling and both trust~~

~~-listen to my feelings~~

- 3 Kuala Lumpur is a crowded city.

~~- main city and also landmark in Malaysia~~

~~- a lot of tourist will come to this place for side-seeing. popular destinations~~

~~- Petronas Twin Towers~~

- 4 My hometown is a good place to live in.

~~- Clean environment~~

~~- unpolluted can breath fresh air~~

~~- Affordable housing compared to the city~~

~~-~~

- 5 I am happy.